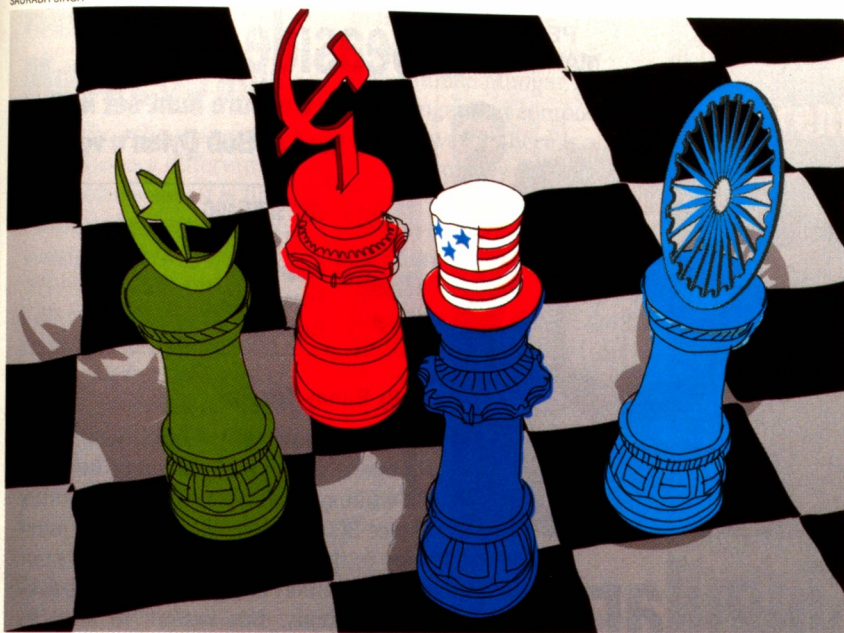




YESTERDAY AGAIN

A manifesto for the new world order explains why liberal democracies like India should worry about autocracies in Beijing and Moscow



THE RETURN OF HISTORY AND THE END OF DREAMS

by ROBERT KAGAN

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■ By S. Prasannarajan

Almost two decades ago, when communism unravelled itself as the biggest lie of the 20th century, Francis Fukuyama, then of the Rand Corporation, experienced this epiphany. The triumph of liberal democracy marked, he wrote in a much-debated essay titled *The End of History?* in the American journal *The National Interest*, "the end point of mankind's ideological evolution". In *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), he would give a book-length elaboration of the argument that looked perfectly in tune with the post-Wall, post-Soviet times. Fukuyama's piece of "endology" would be suitably challenged by other prophets from the academia as ghosts in nationalist rags swarmed the so-called liberated lands. Robert Kagan, Conservative thinker and Republican presidential candidate John McCain's adviser on foreign

policy, is obviously provoked—and for alliterative purposes of the title, inspired—by the fellow Conservative grand-sweep guru. *The Return of History and the End of Dreams* is a smart polemic that brings out, in not so many words, the dissolving optimism of the post-Cold War world.

The new wars won't be a clash of civilisations; the struggle for domination in the 21st century will be driven by the passions and paranoia of regional powers suffering from status anxieties. America may continue to be the singular superpower, but others, including liberal democracies and unbridled autocracies—Russia, China, India, Europe, Japan and Iran—are competing for great-power glory. Particularly ominous is the rise of Russia ("if Russia was where history most dramatically ended two decades ago, today it is where history has most dramatically returned") and China ("today the Chinese believe that their nation's ancient centrality, appropriately adjusted for the times and circumstances, can, should, and will be restored"). The wealthier Russia has not become a liberal democracy, much to the disappointment of Europe, but a neo-Czarist

power. China, deeply suspicious of the conspiring other, is perhaps the most paranoid nation on earth.

Then there is India, another regional power with a sense of manifest destiny. "Yet India is not some disembodied call centre suspended in the global ether. It is a nation of flesh and blood, with all the passions, resentments, and ambitions of the human soul." The central concern of the book is the ascent of autocracy, brilliantly analysed in the section titled "The axis of democracy and the association of autocrats". The rulers in Beijing and Moscow don't give a damn to the virtues of liberal democracy. "They believe their large and fractious nations need order and stability in order to prosper. They believe that the vacillations and chaos of democracy would impoverish and shatter their nations, and in the case of Russia already did so." As Kagan argues, while celebrating the death of history, the modern liberal mind could not have anticipated the possibility of autocrats in a globalised world. The autocrats in China and Russia may not be exporters of their ideology any longer, but "they can and do offer autocrats somewhere to run when the democracies turn hostile". Absolutely true; Rangoon, Khartoum, Pyongyang and Tehran are indebted.

In such a world, Kagan is not particularly worried about the evil of radical Islamism. Modernisation and globalisation may have inflamed the Islamist rage but ultimately tradition cannot triumph over modernity even though, armed with modern weapons, it can kill and cause global horrors. The real threat comes from elsewhere, and only a "concert of democracies" can contain it. "True realism about international affairs means understanding that a nation's foreign policy is heavily shaped by the nature of its government." Unfortunately, at times, such common sense eludes a democracy like India, which doesn't realise the strategic interest in supporting democratic aspirations in autocracies we keep romancing.

The Return of History is not a piece of advice to the leader of the free world alone. It asks, with rare argumentative brio, democracies like India to step out of the illusion of normalcy—and listen to the whispers of history. ■